

6. FREEDOM

6.1 Freedom and Determinism Revision Notes

Key Questions:

- What is the relationship between freedom and determinism?
- Can free will coexist with a deterministic universe?
- How do different philosophical traditions approach the concepts of freedom and determinism?

Philosophers:

1. Baruch Spinoza (1632-1677)

- **Viewpoint: Hard Determinism**
- **Argument:** Spinoza argued that everything in the universe, including human actions, is determined by the laws of nature. He believed that free will is an illusion, as our choices are the result of prior causes and the necessity of nature. For Spinoza, true freedom is understanding the necessity of our actions and aligning ourselves with the rational order of the universe.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics argue that Spinoza's deterministic view undermines moral responsibility, as it suggests individuals cannot be held accountable for their actions if they are entirely determined by external factors.

2. Immanuel Kant (1724-1804)

- **Viewpoint: Compatibilism**
- **Argument:** Kant proposed a compatibilist view, suggesting that freedom and determinism can coexist. He argued that while our actions may be determined by natural laws, we can still be considered free if we act according to our rational will and moral laws. For Kant, moral responsibility is preserved because individuals can choose to act in accordance with duty, even within a deterministic framework.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics of Kant's compatibilism argue that it fails to address the deeper philosophical implications of determinism, questioning whether true freedom can exist if our choices are ultimately determined by prior causes.

3. Jean-Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- **Viewpoint: Existentialism and Radical Freedom**
- **Argument:** Sartre famously asserted that "existence precedes essence," emphasizing the idea that individuals are radically free to create their own values and meaning in an indifferent universe. He rejected determinism, arguing that humans are condemned to be free and must take responsibility for their choices. For Sartre, freedom is an inherent aspect of human existence, and individuals must confront the anxiety that comes with this freedom.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics argue that Sartre's radical freedom can lead to existential despair and moral relativism, as it places the burden of meaning-making solely on the individual without any objective moral framework.

4. Daniel Dennett (1942-Present)

- **Viewpoint: Compatibilism with a Naturalistic Approach**
- **Argument:** Dennett offers a modern compatibilist perspective, arguing that free will is compatible with a deterministic understanding of the universe. He suggests that free will should be understood in terms of the ability to act according to one's desires and rational deliberation, even if those desires are shaped by prior causes. For Dennett, acknowledging determinism does not negate the meaningfulness of human freedom.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics may argue that Dennett's view does not adequately address the implications of determinism on moral responsibility, questioning whether individuals can truly be held accountable for actions that are ultimately determined by prior events.

Conclusion: The exploration of freedom and determinism encompasses a variety of perspectives, including the hard determinism of Spinoza, the compatibilism of Kant and Dennett, and the radical freedom of Sartre. Understanding these diverse viewpoints enriches our comprehension of the complexities surrounding human agency, moral responsibility, and the nature of existence.